that it could change voting preferences.

The 2011 Census findings are telling on both fronts—whether tribal Christian numbers have increased, or whether tribals are Hindus or not. Narayanpur district had a population of 139,000 in 2011, of which 92.38 per cent or 129,000 people reported themselves as Hindus while 0.43 per cent or a mere 600 people as Christians. Christian leaders, however, claim that more than 1,000 Christians alone have been displaced in the recent attacks. In other words, many Christians have not reported themselves as Christians or have converted in the past decade. Of the total population in Narayanpur district, around 77 per cent is said to be tribal, and with the Hindu population at 92 per cent, it follows that a large section of tribals have reported themselves as Hindus. Interestingly, 6.11 per cent of the population in Narayanpur reported themselves as 'Others'. They are estimated to be tribals who report themselves as neither Hindu nor Christian but as tribal. But Hindu, Christian or tribal, religion has turned man against man in Chhattisgarh and made him a pawn in the godless game of politics. ■

Photographs by ANI



SEASON OF ALLIANCES
VBA's Prakash Ambedkar with Uddhav, PRP leader Kawade with CM Eknath Shinde

standing up to the former in the use of raw street power. The Sena also protested the renaming of the Marathwada University at Aurangabad after Ambedkar and used this to spread its wings among the Marathas, Hindu Dalits and OBCs. Leaders like Athawale and Kawade are the products of the 'Namantar' movement (1978–1994) that called for the renaming of the varsity.

The Sena also protested the Maharashtra government's decision to print Ambedkar's book, *Riddles in Hinduism* (1987), with its controversial references to Hindu deities.

In 2003, Uddhav, who had just taken over as the Sena's working president, reached out to the Buddhist Dalits using the 'ShivShakti- Bhimshakti' initiative, which called for the unity of the two social forces. This met with limited success though the Sena's former foe and Dalit Panthers leader, poet Namdeo Dhasal, joined hands with it. Before his demise in 2012, Sena chief Bal Thackeray had ensured that Union minister of state Ramdas Athawale, who is now with the BJP, joined the saffron alliance. Gradually, the Sena has also built a base among the Buddhist Dalits in the state.

NEO-BUDDHISTS MAKE UP 7-8% OF THE STATE'S POPULATION AND ARE THE LARGEST DALIT GROUP

The fresh alliance with the VBA is expected to make up for the attrition in the Sena ranks after Shinde's midnight coup in June 2022. Prakash said talks with the Sena were on for the civic polls. The Congress and NCP, however, he added, were opposed to their inclusion in the larger Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA). A senior VBA leader said that Uddhav could set aside some seats for them from his party's quota.

The Congress-NCP apprehensions stem from the VBA's role in the 2019 general election. At that time, the VBA had contested in alliance with the All-India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) and was blamed for the Congress-NCP defeat in eight seats by walking away with the anti-incumbency vote. The AIMIM wrested the saffron stronghold of Aurangabad from the Sena. In the subsequent assembly election, the VBA, which had contested alone, drew a blank, but was runners-up in 10 seats.

A senior Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) leader too admits that the fate of their alliance hinged on VBA's seat-sharing demands. "We cannot afford to set aside too many seats for them, as our votes may migrate to the BJP or the MNS," he said. "In 2003, the ShivShakti-BhimShakti agenda had gelled on the ground, giving us some success. We will have to work towards that end again. Otherwise, this will turn out to be an alliance between leaders, not the cadre."

A veteran of the Dalit Panthers movement, however, noted that, for some youth, the BJP was not the anathema it once was. They could vote for the party regardless of their leaders' affiliations.

"Political parties want an RPI faction with themselves as it helps them project a progressive image... (but) if Prakash and the Sena join hands, it will be a welcome move and birth a new social engineering model," says P.G. Jogdand, former dean of the faculty of arts, University of Mumbai. That said, the larger Dalit movement, he noted, was in bad shape and confined to celebrating events such as Ambedkar's birth and death anniversaries. RPI leaders were also concerned with "individual mobility and individual benefits" rather than the greater common good, he observed. It does not matter to the mainstream parties. ■